With that, Neil produces an electric fan and says that, in recognition of his huge sacrifice, Jacques will have to down a few beers with the wind blowing in his face, just the way he likes it.

So the fines and the humour continue long into the night.

It had been a remarkable Test match, decided by one of the very finest innings I had ever seen.

England had batted first and, even though we secured a useful first innings lead of 83 runs, the home team seemed to have put themselves in a winning position when they scored 363 in their second innings. We were set 281 to win; in all the history of Test cricket at Edgbaston, no team had ever successfully chased such a total.

Graeme and Neil provided a solid foundation with an opening partnership of 65, but we lost four quick wickets and were battling at 93 for four. Graeme and I steadied the chase, adding 78 runs in an hour and 40 minutes, but a further 100 runs were still required when I was out for 27, edging a catch to first slip.

Our captain was simply not going to be denied. Batting under constant pressure for almost six hours, he proved magnificently resolute. He was joined by Mark Boucher and led us to victory by five wickets, finishing unbeaten on 154 out of our total of 283 for five. With courage and concentration, with great skill, he had single-handedly transformed a match we would have lost nine times out of 10 into a sensational triumph.

Edgbaston security staff eventually persuade us to leave the ground just before midnight but our celebrations are only just beginning. A substantial group of players, including Paul Harris and me, head for Broad Street in the centre of Birmingham where we crawl from pub to pub, and then from club to club.

We arrive back at our hotel just after five o'clock in the morning and decide it is still not quite time for bed, so we order more beers to our team room. Then, an hour or so later, with our party still in full swing, the fire alarm goes off and an emergency announcement says it is necessary to